

Improv activity notes

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Openers

Practices that establish focus, trust, and the working container.

Jesse's Opening Meditation

RITUAL

Purpose: Transition students from ordinary life into class readiness; Ground students in breath, body, and presence.

PLAYERS Whole class	TIME 5-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Low
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Skills: presence / risk agreement / anti-judgment / class container

How it works

1. Breathe deeply from the belly - Jesse frames this as breathing from where *chi* lives. Eyes closed.
2. Notice what appears in the darkness - floaters, light, images, whatever arises.
3. Imagine a grounding cord running from the spine down to the center of the earth.
4. Body scan: toes to feet to ankles to legs to torso to shoulders to neck to head to fingertips.
5. Gratitude pause: "Think of all the people that came before, all the little choices they had to make for you to be here right now in this place."
6. Jesse references *The Four Agreements* by Don Miguel Ruiz and may recommend students read it. Three agreements follow:
 - **Take a risk** - do something you haven't done before.
 - **Release judgment of others** in the room.
 - **Release judgment of yourself** for the length of class.
7. Return to breath: three deep breaths with hands raised high, released with an audible sigh.
8. Open eyes.

What success looks like

Students enter class present, risk-ready, and with reduced self-monitoring - ready to commit and fail visibly.

Participant cues

- The meditation runs 5-10 minutes - arrive ready to commit to it fully.
- Let the framing work for you even if it's unfamiliar; the functional purpose is presence and openness.
- The three agreements are the heart of it: take a risk, release judgment of others, release judgment of yourself.
- The last agreement is the hardest - put self-judgment away for the length of class and allow play to happen.

Facilitator notes

- This is a Flying Pig house ritual, not a generic warmup - do not substitute or abbreviate casually.
- The three agreements map directly to improv skills: risk to bold offers; releasing judgment of others to acceptance; releasing self-judgment to commitment and recovery.
- Jesse occasionally invites students to notice the *third eye* - the seat of inner vision in the Ajna chakra tradition - as part of the inward awareness phase.
- Students may be surprised by the length, tone, or spiritual framing; a brief warning or introduction can reduce this friction.
- At Flying Pig, Jesse prefers the meditation be done in her established form and sequence.

Warmups

Fast activities for attention, connection, energy, and ensemble readiness.

Zip Zap Zop

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Focus; Eye contact.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: focus / eye contact / reaction speed / recovery

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. The sequence passes in order: Zip to Zap to Zop.
- Each pass requires clear eye contact and a deliberate point to the receiver.
- The sequence resets after Zop and continues.

What success looks like

Passes are fast, clear, and connected - eye contact made before the word lands, no hesitation, mistakes acknowledged and moved through quickly.

Participant cues

- Make eye contact before you say the word - the point and word should arrive together.
- Don't overthink which word comes next; trust the sequence and stay present.
- When you make a mistake, recover quickly and keep the energy moving.

Facilitator notes

- This is a good activity to introduce celebrating failures: raise your hands and say joyfully, "I failed!" - then move on.
- Once players are comfortable, instigate a "war" by passing the sequence right back to the player who sent it to you.
- Encourage players to speed up after a few rounds.
- Beginners start with standard Zip Zap Zop; introduce variants once the base is comfortable.
- Watch for: hesitation before passing, weak eye contact, or players dwelling on mistakes instead of moving through them.

Pass the Clap

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Build eye contact; Build group focus.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: eye contact / timing / shared impulse

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. One player locks eyes with any other player.
- The two players attempt to clap at exactly the same time.
- The receiver then locks eyes with another player and passes the clap.
- The clap may go to any player in the circle, including the one who just passed it.
- The goal is a clean shared clap - connection matters more than speed.

What success looks like

Claps feel simultaneous and mutual - like two people arriving at the same moment together rather than one person signaling and the other reacting.

Participant cues

- Establish real eye contact before initiating - don't clap until you both know it's happening.
- A clean slow clap is better than a rushed messy one.
- Don't anticipate; wait for the shared moment to emerge.
- Missed claps are useful feedback, not failures - recover and move on.

Facilitator notes

- Eye contact is the setup; the clap is the agreement - not the other way around.
- This exercise reveals who is actually connecting versus who is performing the idea of connection.
- Strong players make the receiving player feel seen and clear before initiating.
- Watch for: players clapping before real contact is made, rushing the pass, or becoming self-conscious after a miss.

Sound Ball

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Object work; sound/movement matching; trajectory.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: object work / sound/movement matching / trajectory

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. The object begins as a buzzing, softball-sized imaginary object.
- A player throws the ball with a sound to any other player.
- On the catch, the receiver repeats the sound the thrower made.
- Then the receiver creates a new sound and throws to the next player.
- Preserve the object's weight, size, and trajectory throughout.

What success looks like

The object feels consistent and real as it travels around the circle; sounds are honored on the catch and invented freshly on the throw.

Participant cues

- Repeat the sound when you catch - don't skip it or change it immediately.
- Honor the object's weight and size; don't let it drift into something different.
- Track where the object is coming from and receive it at the right trajectory.

Facilitator notes

- It's useful to demonstrate object work by pulling the Sound Ball out of an imaginary cabinet before play begins.
- Coach when the object returns to you - use those moments to reset object consistency.
- Watch for: receivers skipping the catch sound, the object losing its physical properties, or trajectory being ignored.

A to B

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Warm up associative thinking; Reduce hesitation.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: association / speed / listening / low filter

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. Player 1 says any word.
- Each player immediately responds with the first word that comes to mind - no hesitation.
- The goal is speed and honesty, not cleverness or originality.
- In larger circles, multiple starting words can be active simultaneously.

What success looks like

The circle flows fast and continuously; responses are honest rather than clever; players stop monitoring themselves and just play.

Participant cues

- Say the first word that comes to mind - the "obvious" association is usually the right one.
- Don't pause to evaluate whether your response is interesting or funny.
- Try not to repeat a word someone else has already used.
- In A to C, your job is to step past the most predictable word into the next connected idea.
- In No Nouns, watch for yourself defaulting to objects, names, or places.
- Once comfortable, challenge yourself with a different methodology - rhyming, matching the first letter or sound, or starting with the last letter or sound of the previous word.

Facilitator notes

- The exercise is about lowering the filter, not expanding vocabulary - keep the emphasis on momentum.
- Start multiple words simultaneously in large circles to increase load and force presence.
- Encourage students to reflect on how they find their word - is the association based on sound, color, feeling, or something else?
- Watch for: players trying to be funny, pausing too long, responding to a previous word rather than the most recent one, or the circle slowing into polite caution.

Exercises

Skill-building structures for deliberate practice and coaching.

D'Jever

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Practice building a coherent sentence one word at a time; Encourage players to listen to the developing grammar of the offer.

PLAYERS Circle / sequence	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Mid-Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: one-word sentence construction / restraint / clean endings

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. Player 1 begins with "D'Jever" (short for "Did you ever").
- Player 2 adds a verb. Each following player adds one word at a time.
- The sentence ends at its first reasonable completion point - the next player starts a new sentence with "D'Jever."
- Example: "D'Jever" to "eat" to "a" to "sandwich" to "while" to "crying?"

What success looks like

Sentences complete cleanly at their first natural ending; players serve the sentence rather than forcing a clever turn; restarts are confident.

Participant cues

- Listen for grammar and rhythm - your job is to serve the sentence, not surprise everyone.
- End at the first reasonable completion; don't keep adding clauses to make it funnier.
- Don't hesitate searching for a clever word - a simple word that fits is always right.

Facilitator notes

- Coach players to end at the first reasonable completion - this is the core discipline of the exercise.
- A clear, simple question is better than a long, tortured one.
- Watch for: sentences extended past their natural end, players trying to force a joke, or grammatically tangled constructions.

Short Form

Self-contained games with a clear premise, pattern, or performance rule.

Spelling Bee

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice fast group coordination; Practice one-word-at-a-time team speaking.

PLAYERS Seven players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: one-word team speaking / character under constraint / host escalation

Setup notes

Materials: Optional bell/host framing; no documented required prop

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Optional host introduction

Pronouncer: Welcome to the (setting) Spelling Bee. Competitors, please introduce yourselves. [Each team introduces themselves one word at a time.] Pronouncer: Our first word is (audience get or host-chosen word - escalate from simple to difficult to invented). [Game begins.]

How it works

One host runs the spelling bee; two teams of three compete. The host establishes a setting (e.g., fourth grade, senior center, prison).

Teams introduce themselves one word at a time.

When asked to spell a word, the team: repeats the word to claps to spells one letter at a time to says the word again to claps.

The host follows up with questions: "Use it in a sentence," "Define it," "Give me the etymology," etc.

Words escalate: simple real words to harder real words to invented or absurd words.

Example:

- Host: "Your word is 'banana.'"
- Team: "Banana. [clap] B-A-N-A-N-A. Banana. [clap]"
- Host: "Use it in a sentence."
- Team (one word at a time): "I / once / ate / a / banana / on / the / moon."

In beginner class, the coach typically serves as host, freeing students to focus on team speaking and character.

What success looks like

Teams go fast and stay in character; correct spelling matters less than confident shared commitment; invented words are defined with total authority.

Participant cues

Speed and character over spelling accuracy. Commit to wrong answers confidently.

Your team introduction establishes a shared identity - make it playable, not generic.

Treat invented words as real. Define them with authority and let the definition reveal character.

Facilitator notes

Hosts: escalate word difficulty gradually. Early words let the audience learn the pattern; later words create pressure and absurdity.

Follow-up questions should heighten character or world - not just be administrative checkboxes.

Common failure: players prioritize correctness over rhythm and the game loses energy. Redirect to confidence and speed.

Thunderdome

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Two team lines face off: the host calls a domain and keeps a rhythm (a squeaky pig, in Flying Pig practice) while active players alternate naming things in the domain on the beat - fall behind, repeat, or miss the domain and you rotate to the back of your line.

PLAYERS Host + 4 or more players (two roughly equal teams)	TIME 3-8 min estimated	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY High
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Skills: quick recall / rhythm / listening / category thinking / performing under pressure / ensemble rotation

Setup notes

Materials: Squeaky toy or other rhythm-keeper (optional)

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

How it works

- A host plus 4+ players in two roughly equal team lines; the front player of each line is active.
- The host calls a domain (Dog Breeds, Countries in Africa, Frozen Foods) and keeps a steady rhythm - observed: squeaking a toy pig.
- The two active players alternate on the beat, naming things in the domain.
- Failure = falling behind the rhythm, repeating an answer, or naming something outside the domain. The failed player goes to the back of their line and the next player steps up.
- In shows the audience chants "Thunderdome! Thunderdome!" at each rotation.
- Time-boxed: the host declares the end; no formal winner.

What success looks like

Answers snap onto the beat; rotations are fast and celebrated; the audience joins the chant unprompted; energy rises as domains get harder.

Participant cues

- An imperfect answer on the beat beats a perfect answer that's late.
- Go to the back of the line cheerfully - the rotation is part of the show.
- Listen: repeats are failures too.

Facilitator notes

- The rhythm is the game; keep it steady and audible.
- Change domains before they run dry.
- In class, the coach hosts; structure is otherwise identical (chant optional).

Closers

High-energy structures suited to ending a class, workshop, or show.

Name Game

CLOSER

Purpose: Learn names; Build physical commitment.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 5-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY High
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Skills: name recall / group cohesion / physical offers

Setup notes

Materials: Music/audio, usually Uptown Funk

How it works

One player states their name and performs a physical motion. The whole group repeats the name and mirrors the motion back. Continue around the circle until every player has introduced themselves. Optionally follow with a "ripple" pass: point to any player, the group names them and does their motion together.

What success looks like

Every player's name can be recalled by the group without hesitation; motions are mirrored with commitment and warmth; the room feels connected and supportive rather than pressurized.

Participant cues

- Make the motion big enough to read and simple enough to repeat.
- The goal is not dance skill; the goal is commitment and group memory.
- The group should support imperfect recall rather than making mistakes feel costly.
- The exercise works best when the room treats each motion as a gift.

Facilitator notes

- Watch for self-consciousness - it's the main blocker. Model commitment and normalize imperfection early.
- Coach players whose actions are too small or too complex to repeat. The motion needs to be big enough to read and simple enough for the group to reproduce.
- The goal is not dance skill; the goal is commitment and group memory.